How it works

The main indicators governments use to monitor the economy are based on surveys of individuals, businesses, and government departments. A national statistics agency is usually charged with running the survey, and then calculating the figures. The agency will look at the economy, business, industry and trade, the employment and labor markets, and society in general. The "headline indicators" generally relate to parts of the economy that have the most impact on people's daily lives, and might include assessments of the likelihood that individuals will find employment, whether their pay will go up or down, and whether businesses will be able to expand.

1884 the year the US Bureau of Labor Statistics was formed to analyze data